Chapter Fifteen

# Linguistic Bias or a Chance to Get Ahead: Linguistic Repertoires in Aruban and Curaçaoan Schools

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<<alt-text>> Photo of an entrance to a school. Five steps lead up to a closed metal gate that is flanked by two signs. On the left, “welcome” is written in six different languages. The sign on the right reads “Bringing education to life since 1941.” Through the gate is a sunny hallway.

Figure 14.1. Entrance to a secondary school in Aruba. Photo by Keisha Wiel.

Multilingualism has long been a feature on the islands of Aruba and Curaçao. On a day-to-day basis this means that teachers and students continuously negotiate which languages can be used under what circumstances in school settings. This sort of negotiation was evident in one Curaçaoan high school classroom on the last day of homeroom before *proefwerkweek* (exam week). Tension filled the air as the teacher, *Yufrou* Tjon (Miss Tjon), greeted the students in Dutch with news that they were underperforming in their classes. *Yufrou* Tjon wanted to know if the teachers could help. Several students looked nervously at one another, unsure of what to say. Yufrou Tjon called on Julaika, who noted that since they hadn't received grades all semester, the students didn't know how they were doing. While trying to convey her frustration, Julaika struggled to explain herself in Dutch. She looked to a classmate, Miloushka, who took over and switched into Papiamentu (a creole language with features from Spanish, Portuguese, Dutch, English, Twi, Kimbundu, and Arawak, spoken widely in the island nation of Curaçao, Aruba, and Bonaire and the language that the students spoke most comfortably) to elaborate: "*Djis pa nos wak kon nos ta para…*" (Just so we can see where we stand…). Before Miloushka could finish, Yufrou Tjon firmly stated in Dutch, "*praat Nederlands*" (speak Dutch). Julaika let out a "*hesusei"* (oh my God) and struggled to continue in Dutch as she took over from Miloushka.

While Miloushka pleaded, another student, Marie, noted that although students supported each other through study sessions, certain students did not want the support. She singled out Bethaliza for not receiving help. The attention turned to Bethaliza, who nervously explained herself. Struggling to communicate in Dutch, almost tearfully, Bethaliza looked to Yufrou Tjon and asked if she could use Papiamentu. Yufrou Tjon noticed the hurt in Bethaliza's eyes and warmly assented.

In this intimate classroom dynamic, teacher and students balanced communicative efficacy and personal consideration against educational protocols. School language policies in Curaçao (and Aruba) prioritize the use of Dutch as the language of instruction in high school, positioning Dutch as one of the languages of instruction in Curaçao and *the* language of instruction in Aruba, contributing to the attempted erasure of Papiamentu in the classroom. Yufrou Tjon maintained official policy by correcting students when they spoke Papiamentu. As the linguistic gatekeeper, she only allowed Bethaliza to speak Papiamentu when sharing her personal story. On the islands, although there is a general acceptance that Papiamentu has a place in educational settings for cultural identity purposes, dominant ideologies associate Dutch, not Papiamentu, with educational success. This ideology was reflected through Yufrou Tjon's opinion that students should always use Dutch in the classroom in order to master it.

In this postcolonial society where power structures go far beyond the teacher/student dynamic, structural inequalities are maintained in part through **linguistic gatekeeping**–the regulation of language choice, including determining which languages may be used, as well as which may not—in educational institutions. However, as I will show in this chapter, teachers and students are also creative social actors who exercise agency in their language practices, sometimes flouting official policies and translanguaging in order to prioritize communicative efficacy. In this chapter, I start by providing background about multilingualism on the islands before presenting evidence from several interactions at schools that show how students and teachers use their full **linguistic repertoires** - the complete set of languages and language varieties that a person speaks - in these assertive ways.

## "The Four Languages" and Multilingualism in Aruba and Curaçao

Papiamentu, English, Dutch, and Spanish are the four main languages that are spoken on the island nations of Aruba and Curaçao. Each language has its own historical significance as the flow of colonialism, immigration, and tourism has shaped the islands. Throughout the colonization period, various European countries took control of Aruba and Curaçao. In 1513, the viceroy of Hispaniola, Diego Colón, declared the islands useless and sent the resident Indigenous Caquetio (Arawakan speaking) people to be enslaved in what is now the Dominican Republic and Haiti. After the Netherlands gained independence from Spain, the Dutch West India Company gained control of the islands in 1633 and set up a colony along Santa Anna Bay. The few Caquetio who remained on the islands herded livestock, while the Dutch trafficked enslaved people from Africa for trade, making it at one point the largest trading post for the Atlantic Slave Trade. Around the same time, Sephardic Jews fleeing Spain and Portugal during the Inquisition also settled on the islands as merchants (Rupert 2012).

This colonial dynamic contributed to the four languages that thrived on the islands. Dutch was used in an official capacity, while the emergent creole language Papiamentu was used in other parts of society, not only among enslaved people but also in Jewish and Dutch families, where children learned Papiamentu through their *yayas* (enslaved nannies) (Arion 1998).

In 1914, when oil was found in Lake Maracaibo in Venezuela, Standard Oil of New Jersey (ExxonMobil) and Royal Dutch Shell used the harbors of Aruba and Curaçao to refine the crude oil. Since Exxon was an American company, they preferentially hired immigrants from the English Caribbean, leading to the quadrupling of Aruba's population, as a blend of Caribbean Englishes called San Nicolas English became a prominent language alongside Dutch and Papiamentu. Recently, as American cultural influences have become more prominent through music, television, and social media on both islands, English has gained even more prominence.

Spanish has always had a presence on the islands tracing to early Sephardic Jewish populations, as well as proximity and trade with nearby Venezuela and recent patterns of migration from Venezuela, Colombia, and the Dominican Republic.

Through my position as a child of the **diaspora**, I went into ethnographic fieldwork with my own thoughts on how the various languages were used. I noticed how Spanish-speaking immigrants worked in hotels, small restaurants, and *truk'i pans* (food trucks). I noticed that those immigrants often spoke in *Papiañol* (a mixture of Papiamentu and Spanish) when communicating with locals. I also noticed that upper-scale stores and restaurants often required that their employees speak "The Four Languages" to interact with tourists. Teenagers often spoke to each other in American English in everyday interactions while older generations **translanguaged** between "The Four Languages." But I also observed how quick locals were to switch to Dutch or English with white tourists from the Netherlands or the United States.

As an ethnographer working in high school classrooms, I discovered that there was a continued emphasis on Dutch as the dominant language of education, but students were also comfortable speaking in English and Papiamentu, and teachers continued to use Papiamentu as an explanatory tool when all else failed. In this chapter, I present findings from participant observation in classrooms and interviews with students and teachers at two schools, one located in Aruba and the other in Curaçao. In addition, I gave students GoPros to record their interactions during lunch time and to create vlogs (video blogs). I used this visual method to give students a chance to record their own interactions without the presence of an adult, which allowed me to examine their linguistic interactions when an authority figure was not present.

## Community through a Shared Linguistic Repertoire

At Kolegio Maria Liberia in Curaçao, the students were in a transitional class. In the Dutch system, secondary school starts with *brugklas* (literally meaning bridge class), which is supposed to help transition students from primary to secondary school, equivalent to middle school in the United States. The students ranged in age from fourteen to sixteen, and the parents of most of the students were from Curaçao. Although the linguistic backgrounds of most students were similar and they spoke Papiamentu at home, at least two students spoke Dutch at home.

This shared linguistic repertoire became a marker of an intragroup community at school. Within an educational setting, students who create this type of community do so out of solidarity and need (García-Sànchez 2014). In the high schools, there was an unspoken familiarity surrounding how language worked and could be used in different environments and peer groups. For instance, at Kolegio Maria Liberia, students formed cliques based on interests. Depending on who was part of that clique, one language or a mixture of languages was spoken. But for class assignments, there was a shared understanding that the dominant language was Dutch. This presumption was evident in the interaction between students that Sanaida and Noraly recorded one day during the lunch break. They had an exam in Physics and the whole class was concerned about it. Although some students did study for the exam, there was a fear that many were not adequately prepared. Noraly nervously mentioned in English on her vlog that she did not "learn" for this exam to which Naphtaly, her friend, laughed and said in English: "The word is 'study' NOT 'learn'!" While students were joking about Noraly's word choice, Sanaida nervously turned to the group and asked, in Papiamentu, about the exam. Rudsel, a student who spoke mostly Dutch at school, began to explain a physics problem the group was reviewing together. Excerpt 1 details the conversation starting at this point.

Transcription note: Spoken English is represented by bold text. Spoken Dutch is represented by italics. All other talk is in Papiamentu. All capitalized text represents a translation of the original talk in Dutch or Papiamentu.

EXCERPT **1.**

1. Rudsel: *Je dingens… maar ze geven niet de voor afstand en midden afstand* YOUR THINGS…BUT THEY DON'T GO THROUGH THE FRONT DISTANCE AND MIDDLE DISTANCE
2. Lucio: **yeah**
3. Sanaida: No e koi mi no kier sa. Mi kier sa kon ta asi e koi pintura… NO, I DON'T WANT TO KNOW THAT. I WANT TO KNOW HOW TO DO THE DRAWING…
4. Sanaida: M'a lubida. Un tin ku yega e *middel punt*? I FORGOT. DON'T YOU HAVE TO GO TO THE MIDDLE POINT?
5. Rudsel: **Ok**
6. ((Shanuska motions to Sanaida))
7. Shanuska: Wak wak, esun ta bai meimei. *Dus* e ta bai mei mei di e, e punta. Pasa meimei di e *op is middel punt…* LOOK LOOK, THIS ONE GOES IN THE MIDDLE. SO, IT GOES IN THE MIDDLE OF THE, THE POINT. PASSES THROUGH AT THE CENTER POINT…
8. Sanaida: ((shushes other students so she can hear))
9. Shanuska: Paso e di dos ta bai um *evenwijdig met de… met de…* e liña abou. Anto despues bai dor di e *F twee*. Despues esun ta bai for di e dos. …bai para na e liña mei mei. Despues bo lo *evenwijdig met de…***whatever!** Anto korda bon, kaminda bo pòtlot

bai… Bo no ta hisa bo pòtlot. Bo ta *gewoon* sigi mesora. BECAUSE THE SECOND ONE GOES UM PARALLEL TO THE… TO THE… THE LINE BELOW. AND AFTERWARDS IT GOES THROUGH F2. AFTERWARDS, THE OTHER ONE GOES FROM THE SECOND… …IT STANDS AT THE MIDDLE LINE. AFTERWARDS YOU WILL GO PARALLEL TO THE…WHATEVER! AND REMEMBER. WHERE YOUR PENCIL GOES…YOU DON'T LIFT YOUR PENCIL. YOU JUST CONTINUE RIGHT AWAY.

This interaction between several physics students reveals that language flexibility was key to student interaction and community building. The intragroup community and shared multilingual repertoire among the students made it possible for Shanuska to explain the physics problem to Sanaida, free from concerns about which languages were permitted for talking about physics. This parallels the casual translanguaging that I observed happening almost everywhere in the community outside of school.

This interaction also shows how communicative practice through several languages can sometimes be difficult when one of the languages is mainly heard in institutional spaces. While the students easily translanguaged in order to effectively communicate, it was also apparent how Dutch was a struggle, particularly for Shanuska. Although she understood enough of the physics problem to explain it to her classmate, she did so mostly in Papiamentu, switching to Dutch only briefly, when she needed to use technical terms they had learned in physics class: "*middel punt"* (middle point), "F twee" (F2), and "*evenwijdig"* (parallel). After struggling to come up with the right word to finish the Dutch phrase "*evenwijdig met de..."* (parallel with the...), she exasperatedly exclaimed "whatever!" in English before returning to Papiamentu.

Many teachers told me that enforcing Dutch as the primary language in the classroom impacted students' learning. When they taught, they would begin in Dutch. Once they realized that their students were not grasping the Dutch terminology, they often switched to Papiamentu or English to explain the new terms. When they felt that their students sufficiently understood, they would go back to speaking Dutch. The chemistry teacher, Yufrou Juliana, mentioned that her reasoning was to help students prepare for exams. Since their final exams came from the Netherlands, students in Aruba and Curaçao needed to be able to navigate Dutch-language exams as well as native Dutch students did, in order to be successful in school.

Teachers like Yufrou Juliana, often pull double duty compared to their counterparts in the Netherlands. They must consistently transition between languages to ensure that their students achieve equivalent linguistic and content knowledge as Dutch students. Based on policies set forth in the public-school board in Curaçao, students must matriculate through school knowing Dutch well enough to attend university in the Netherlands. Many students in secondary education go on to university in the Netherlands. Ironically, most Dutch universities are taught in English to attract students from other European nations.

Shanuska is forced to use Dutch because it's the language that physics is taught in. Specifically for education, the Dutch language is coded as a path to success. Yet, as has been noted in other contexts, the dominant language acts "as the barrier that keeps the very few powerful, White speakers *subiendo* (rising), while it ensures that those whose language practices are different are kept *bajando* (lowering)" (García 2017, 257). This is visible in the way that Shanuska struggles to explain the physics problem. The Dutch words that she knows are specific to physics. On the other hand, in order to explain her point fully she resorted to translanguaging

between Papiamentu, Dutch, and English, using the full breadth of her linguistic repertoire to express her knowledge of physics.

## Students as Arbiters of Language Use in the Classroom

In a second classroom, this one at Scol Di Specialista in Aruba, students were also in a transitional class, but their ages ranged from fifteen to eighteen years old. Their transitional class was taught in both Papiamentu and Dutch with an emphasis on Dutch as they prepared for tertiary school. Scol was broken up into tracts or "units" that focused on specific job sectors. The class I observed was part of the "Service Unit," which focused on tourism. Students learned how to professionally cook for a hotel or restaurant and interned during the final year. Once they finished Scol they were eligible to go to the tertiary school. Tertiary school is a continuation of Scol Di Specialista, which is something between a vocational school and a college. Many of the students in this class had at least one parent that was not born on the island and spoke a language other than Papiamentu at home. Students had parents from Venezuela, Jamaica, and St. Vincent. As a result, the students had differing linguistic repertoires that encompassed several languages.

As there is a hierarchy in language use on the islands, there is also a hierarchy in who gets to impose language choices. This is often exemplified in school settings where exams determine who can get in based on how well they understand Dutch. Elite institutions can often act as a mechanism of gatekeeping often constraining who can attend prestigious schools (Agha 2006, 28). In Aruban and Curaçao schools, Dutch, itself, can act as a gatekeeping tool to educational advancement. Within the classroom, teachers are usually at the top of the hierarchy and determine what language is to be spoken. But within certain classrooms in Aruba and

Curaçao, students can sometimes direct language interactions, as when Bethaliza asked for permission to use Papiamentu in the classroom when she wanted to relate personal challenges.

As an ethnographer, I witnessed students at Scol di Specialista in Aruba appropriating the role of linguistic gatekeeper and expanding, rather than limiting, the number of languages that were used in the classroom when they were going over instructions for a project in their *Drink Leren* (Drink Studies) course. The teacher for the class had been replaced by Yufrou Williams, their *Kook Theorie en Practicum* (Cooking Theory and Practicum) teacher. Yufrou Williams was unsure what the previous teacher had assigned, so she asked the students.

Transcription note: as before, Dutch is in italics, English is bold, and Papiamentu is written in regular font. San Nicolas English (a creole) is underlined. Translation of the talk is capitalized.

**EXCERPT 2.**

1. Yufrou Williams: Yufrou a bisa tur bo mester hinka den dje'le? DID THE TEACHER TELL YOU WHAT YOU HAD TO PUT IN IT?
2. Frankie: Ami'n ta korda. <u>Dat</u> **was like two or three weeks ago.** I DON'T REMEMBER. THAT WAS LIKE TWO OR THREE WEEKS AGO.
3. Jairzinho: No, e a bisa nos pa traha un kos. Inventa bo **drink.** NO, SHE TOLD US TO MAKE SOMETHING. INVENT YOUR DRINK.
4. Frankie: se paso… YEAH BECAUSE…
5. Yufrou Williams: **No rules, anything…**
6. Jamir: E no mester ta un kos ku bo por kumpra den **shop.** IT CANNOT BE SOMETHING THAT YOU CAN BUY IN A STORE
7. Jamir: *Letterlijk*… LITERALLY…

8. Frankie: Se… So yuh **can't like buy the shake and mix it.** Bo mester trah'e. Yuh know blend it, mix it up. YEAH… SO YOU CANNOT BUY THE SHAKE AND MIX IT. YOU HAVE TO MAKE IT. YOU, BLEND IT, MIX IT UP.
9. Yufrou Williams: **So, you have to try it out at home first?**
10. Frankie: Si…YES…
11. Jairzinho: No
12. Frankie: Yeah
13. Yufrou Williams: **Uh yeah…**
14. Yufrou Williams: Kon bo ta hasi'e? Bo ta *gewoon* skibi un reseta i despues spera ku e ta sali bon? HOW ARE YOU GOING TO DO IT? ARE YOU GOING TO JUST WRITE A RECIPE AND AFTERWARDS HOPE THAT IT COMES OUT WELL?
15. Jamir: Si! YES!
16. Yufrou Williams: **Ok…**
17. Frankie: Y'all really gon tell meh… ARE YOU ALL GOING TO TELL ME…
18. Jamir: Ooooh, bo sa kiko, buta **spinach** ku umm… OOOOH, YOU KNOW WHAT, PUT SPINACH WITH UMM…
19. Yufrou Williams: I, e tin ku ta dos berdura of fruta? AND IT HAS TO HAVE TWO VEGETABLES OR FRUIT?
20. Frankie: yeah, it gotta be two YES, IT MUST BE TWO
21. Yufrou Williams: **two, not more than that, not less than that or…**
22. ((Chantell says something softly))
23. Yufrou Williams: *Sorry?* PARDON ME?
24. Chantell: E por ta mas IT CAN BE MORE.

25. Yufrou Williams: E por ta mas si, pero **at least two** tings. IT CAN BE MORE YES, BUT AT LEAST TWO THINGS.

Because the previous teacher didn't leave a lesson plan, Yufrou Williams trusted her students to give the correct information about this assignment. What is notable about this interaction is the way the students drove the choice of languages that were used in the discussion. It started with Frankie, who translanguaged across Papiamentu, San Nicolas English, and English in line 2. The rest of the speakers took this cue and continued to translanguage to explain the assignment using these three languages. Noticeably absent was Dutch. Compared to Kolegio, which was a college preparatory institution, Scol was a school for students looking to get an early start on a profession. Although Dutch generally wasn't spoken in their Drink Studies class, it was spoken in their general classes to prepare them for tertiary school. One common perspective at this school was expressed by *Meneer* Thielman (Mr. Thielman), the gym teacher, who told me that teaching in Dutch was a waste of time since the "Service Unit" at the tertiary school was taught in English to prepare students to engage with American tourists. Given this pedagogical objective, Dutch was not important in courses like Drink Studies. This practical assessment about language utility was reflected in the Scol practicum courses, where students and teachers spoke a mix of Papiamentu and English, even while Dutch was used significantly in theory and subject courses. Like Yufrou Juliana, Yufrou Williams told me that she knew the students struggled with Dutch. She was concerned that they needed to know Dutch terminology because exams came from the Netherlands. Yet, unlike the students at Kolegio who were preparing to study in the Netherlands, many of the students at Scol were planning to stay in Aruba and become part of the American driven tourist industry, where competence in English was more important.

## Discussion

As the examples in this chapter have illustrated, different agents gatekeep language use in schools. Depending on the type of interaction, teachers or students determine which languages can be used. For example, students from Kolegio created a study group where translanguaging happened in order to understand subject-specific ideas and procedures. The shared linguistic repertoire and translanguaging practices among peers allowed Shanuska to help Sanaida with studying for an exam. In other instances, a teacher was clearly in control of classroom language use. Yufrou Tjon's explicit gatekeeping - verbally elaborated with her directive to "Speak Dutch" - left students no room for translanguaging, and other languages were excluded. Only when the tone shifted to accommodate a student's sharing of personal experiences, did Yufrou Tjon allow a codeswitch. In contrast, Yufrou Williams at Skol followed the lead of the Drink Studies students, who took the initiative in their classroom to act as linguistic gatekeepers, opening the gates for multiple language varieties. As these examples show, teachers and students negotiated contextually-sensitive solutions on language use in educational spaces. However, at a national level an established language hierarchy that privileged Dutch over all other languages served as the ultimate gatekeeper, influencing students' success and advancement in education. On the islands, knowing Dutch well allowed students to thrive in school and later attend international universities, all while reinforcing social hierarchies and colonial entanglements.

The full linguistic repertoires of many Aruban and Curacaoan students are not officially represented in the classroom. This has implications not only for their matriculation at secondary school and college, but for their identities as well. In Aruba and Curaçao, language is inextricably tied to cultural identity. Papiamentu bonds the community regardless of race, social

standing, or ethnicity. As Spanish and English become increasingly predominant languages on the islands, identities are shifting to be inclusive of multiple selves. Yet school settings cater to only one of these selves, the one that is attached to the Dutch colonial legacy.

In schools, students have been socialized to understand the world through a Dutch lens. Yet Aruban and Curaçaoan students live different lives than their peers in the Netherlands. And linguistic regulation in educational settings does not align with or take advantage of their multilingual repertoires. Throughout the Caribbean, nations have long grappled with colonial educational institutions and the ways they preserve linguistic barriers (Nero 2015). As examples from this chapter show, students and teachers in Aruban and Curaçaoan schools sometimes subvert educational policies and are flexible in their language use in order to promote camaraderie, teach, and learn. By drawing on students' full linguistic repertoires, teachers and students circumvent, if only partially, the linguistic barriers that have been long imposed through a colonial legacy. Ultimately, changes in educational language policies will be needed in order to create equitable opportunities.

**Reflection and Discussion Questions**

- Describe the hierarchy of languages in Aruba and Curaçao and the ways each of "the four languages" are used in daily life, as opposed to how they are positioned in education. If there is a hierarchy of language in your country or community, how does it impact the lives of the young people you know?
- In what ways did students direct the languages were used in the classrooms in Aruba and Curaçao?

- How does translanguaging create a community amongst students in Aruba and Curacao? What ways have you experienced similar community-building through language in your community?

**Key Concepts**

- Diaspora: a group of people or population that originate from one nation or place but are dispersed throughout different countries through various means such as immigration or forced migration.
- Linguistic Gatekeeping: the regulation of language choice, including determining which languages may be used, as well as which may not, in a given context or situation and by whom.
- Translanguaging: a way of using language that incorporates the multiple varieties in a speaker's linguistic repertoire and that is done without concern for maintaining normative distinctions between one language and another.

**Explore Further**

- To learn more about the relationship between colonialism, language and identity for West Indian communities read Chapter 9.
- To learn more about creole languages and diaspora, read Chapter 14.
- "Speaking Papiamento." An episode of the *Speaking Tongues Podcast.* https://tinyurl.com/Speaking-Papiamento
- "*No Hasi Ko'i Pendeu*." (Do Not do Stupid Things). An episode of the *Vocal Fries Podcast*. https://tinyurl.com/Vocal-Fries

- "Doing Anthropology in Curaçao: An Interview with Dr. Rose Mary Allen." An episode of the *Kultura Desaroyo Podcast*. https://tinyurl.com/Doing-Anthropology
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